Michael F Bergmann

*Six-year window: contributions since 2020-10-29. * = resulted from previous SSHRC support.*

1. Research Contributions Over the Last Six Years

Refereed contributions

2022-07 * Bouchard, D., Cristiá, C., Robert, D., and Bergmann, M. (2022). "Augmented Symphony: An augmented reality application for immersive music listening." Proceedings of EVA London 2022, Electronic Workshops in Computing, BCS Learning & Development, London, UK, July 4–8, 2022, pp. 208–209. DOI: 10.14236/ewic/EVA2022.39.

Other refereed contributions

2025-09 Bergmann, M. "Hallucinating Children: Improvisation After the Algorithmic Shipwreck." Hugarflug: Unstable Systems, annual conference on artistic research, Iceland University of the Arts, Reykjavík, Iceland, September 12, 2025.

2024-10 Bergmann, M. "Beyond Tools: Reimaging Technology as Co-Participants in Performance Design." PQ Symposium: Technologies in Theatre, Performance and Exhibition Design, Prague, Czech Republic, October 16–18, 2024.

2024-03 Bergmann, M., Nathan, H., and Vercosa, J. "Robotics, AI, and the Future of Theatre." USITT Conference & Stage Expo, Seattle, WA, March 20, 2024.

2023-06 Bergmann, M., with ChatGPT. "Envisioning theatre with non-human collaborators: A Paramanifesto." CATR Conference, Dalhousie University, Halifax, NS, June 2023.

2023-06 Bergmann, M. "AI Sentience." Panel on the Implications of AI for Performance Theorists, CATR Conference (online), June 2023.

2022-07 * Bergmann, M. "Augmented Symphony: An augmented reality application for immersive music listening." Paper presented at EVA London 2022, London, UK, July 2022.

2022-05 Bergmann, M., and Thomson, B. "Stepping Back In: Taking the best of virtual delivery to a new in-person experience." Learning & Teaching Conference, TMU, May 2022.

2022-05 Bergmann, M. "Student-driven curriculum development for creative practice." Learning & Teaching Conference, TMU, May 2022.

2021-10 Bergmann, M. "Cultivating Empathy through Robotic Performance." Limits of the Human, Machines Without Limits? Contemporary stage and robotics, University of Lausanne (online), October 2021.

2021-06 Bergmann, M., O'Brien, C., and Thomson, B. "Unapologetically learning together: Adapting Production and Design curriculum to a virtual stage." University of the Arts London (online), June 2021.

2021-05	Bergmann, M., O'Brien, C., and Thomson, B. "Pandemic Performance: Adapting Production and Design curriculum to a virtual stage." Learning & Teaching Conference, Ryerson University, May 2021.
2024-01	Bergmann, M., Carravetta, L., Endahl, M., Robinson, A. D., and ARIA (AI). "Almost Alchemy." Poster, RUBIX, TMU, January 25, 2024.
2020-11	Bergmann, M., and Anderson, J. "l'automate: Robotic Controlled Apparatuses for Circus Performance." Poster, RUBIX, TMU (online), November 2020.

Non-refereed contributions

2022-05	* Cristiá, C., Bouchard, D., Bergmann, M., et al. (2022). Orchestra Remote Delivery during COVID-19 Database. Open data set, Open Science Framework, May 5, 2022. DOI: 10.17605/OSF.IO/WCDU2.
2021	Bergmann, M. F., and McGuire, B. (2021). "Uncanny Text." Belfield Literary Review: New TransAtlantic Dialogues, ed. Gregory Betts and Lucy Collins, Spring 2021, pp. 96–99.
2025-02	Guest lecture on AI in visual generation, open-source models, and ethical usage, Advanced Professional Projection Design (graduate), Yale University, February 14, 2025.
2024-12	Host: "Beyond the Screen: Exploring AI Personhood and Their Representation in Media." The Creative School Catalyst, Toronto, December 12, 2024.
2024-11	Closing keynote: "Wellness for who? An examination of wellness through a research-creation student project." AVARA 2024, OAMK, Oulu, Finland, November 22, 2024.
2024-11	Workshop on projection design, Peterborough Theatre Guild, Peterborough, ON, November 2–3, 2024.
2024-10	Provocation: "Personhood // AI." UKAI Carnival of Shipwreck, Toronto, October 23, 2024.
2024-07	Invited talk on the future of AI in the creative industries. TechTO: AI, Toronto, July 22, 2024.
2024-04	"Improvnetics: Post-anthropocentric performance and improvisational modes for human-AI play." IICSI Research Studio Session, ImprovLab, University of Guelph, April 12, 2024.
2024-04	Panelist on the future of AI in creativity and education, 1st Creative AI Symposium, Creative AI Hub, TMU, April 2, 2024.
2022-01	Roundtable: "What is the future of creativity and AI?" with Debashis Sinha, Robert Clapperton, and Richard Lachman, RUBIX, TMU, January 27, 2022.

Forthcoming contributions

2026	Bergmann, M. “Cultivating Empathy through Robotic Performance.” Chapter in Robots and Other Artificial Agents on Stage: Theoretical Concepts and Artistic Practices, edited by Erica Magris and Izabella Pluta, transcript Verlag (Theatre Studies series). Status: in press

Creative outputs

2026-04 – 2026-05	“Before I Was This.” Generative text work. flashDRIVE: Digital Arts Fundraiser Exhibition, InterAccess, Toronto, April 22 – May 9, 2026. Curated by Miriam Arbus.
2026-02	Nuptials (feature film). Producer, projection design, and live in-camera VFX. Directed by Sean Braune, Para-sight Productions. Official release February 13, 2026 (Freestyle Digital Media). Best World Feature Film, Austin Revolution Film Festival, 2022.
2025-11	The Frankenstein Project. Producer, with Debashis Sinha. Performance Studio Theatre, TMU, November 18–22, 2025.
2025-11	291 by Jade O’Keeffe. Projection co-design with Kristen Ferguson; directed by Lisa Dixon. Peterborough Theatre Guild, November 1–15, 2025.
2025-04	“To my creators…” Solo work exhibited at the Creative AI Symposium, TMU, April 2, 2025; created during the SÍM residency, Reykjavík.
2024-11	AVARA 2024 installation. Led eight students in a semester-long research-creation installation presented at AVARA 2024, OAMK, Oulu, Finland.
2024-06	Shipwreck. Group exhibition with UKAI Projects and five Canadian artists, SÍM Gallery, Reykjavík, Iceland, following a month-long residency; includes solo work “To my creators…”
2024-04	Labour and Us. Workshop series (March 14 – April 17, 2024) and performance, co-created and performed with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson; roundtable with Alan Filewod, Tom Scholte, Cynthia Ashperger, and Judith Thompson. ImprovLab, University of Guelph, April 19, 2024.
2024-01	Almost Alchemy. Two 360° video experiences of improvised research-creation performance. RUBIX, TMU, January 25, 2024.
2023-10	“rocketmanperson.” Improvised performance with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson. Silence, Guelph, October 1, 2023.
2023-04	“Who’s There?” Improvised performance with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson. Silence, Guelph, April 1, 2023.
2023	Living Newspaper 2.0. Projection design; directed by Julie Labagnara. George Luscombe Theatre, Toronto.

2. Other Research Contributions

In April 2026 I co-chaired the 3rd Annual Creative AI Symposium at Toronto Metropolitan University with Dr. Afsoon Soudi, reviewing all 33 submissions and building the program that put researchers, artists, students, and industry in one room to work through what AI is doing to creative practice. The symposium runs out of the Creative AI Hub at The Creative School, where I have sat on the steering committee since 2025. Much of my research now moves through roles like this; organizing, reviewing, and mentoring carry the work to audiences the academy does not reach on its own. I serve on the board of UKAI Projects (2025–present; Technical Advisory Board, 2023–24), an arts organization working at the intersection of culture and emerging technology, and mentored artists of the Setsubun Digital Media Residency at the Japanese Canadian Cultural Centre (December 2025 – February 2026). Peer review includes the EVA London Conference on Electronic Visualisation and the Arts (2023–present), the International Journal of Performance Arts and Digital Media (2024–present), the Canada Foundation for Innovation (2023), the USITT Research and Creative Endeavours Committee (2025–present), and the CATR scholarship and grant juries (2023–present), with judging for the Global Undergraduate Awards (2026). Public talks, including TechTO: AI (2024), take the same questions to industry rooms.

3. Most Significant Career Research Contributions

1. Improvnetics. In performance, a wrong note is material; my doctoral research asks why an AI hallucination should be treated any differently. Improvnetics develops post-anthropocentric, improvisational modes for human-AI co-creation, built through practice with the collective Almost Alchemy and presented at Hugarflug (2025), IICSI (2024), and CATR (2023). It is the framework underneath everything I currently make.

2. * Visual Music / Augmented Symphony (2020–2022). When COVID-19 separated the National Arts Centre Orchestra from its audiences, I joined Cintia Cristiá (PI) and David Bouchard as co-investigator on a SSHRC Partnership Engage Grant to build an augmented reality application that put the orchestra back into listeners' spaces. The partnership produced a refereed EVA London paper, an open data set on remote orchestral delivery, and my working model of what a small, well-aimed partnership can do.

3. Nuptials (2018–2026). Sean Braune and I spent nearly a decade carrying a film from live, in-camera projection VFX — theatrical technique brought onto a film set — through festival recognition (Best World Feature Film, Austin Revolution Film Festival, 2022) to commercial release with Freestyle Digital Media in February 2026.

4. The Uncanny Robots Project (2019). A research-creation program in human-robot performance that began with a dancer, Belinda McGuire, and an industrial robot learning to share a stage; it grew into circus apparatus development with Jonathon Anderson through Cirque du Soleil's Future of Live Entertainment lab, and into undergraduate research training. My current human-AI work stands on what these machines taught me about empathy and co-presence.

5. Shipwreck / "To my creators…" (2024–2025). A month in Reykjavík with UKAI Projects and five Canadian artists at the SÍM residency produced a group exhibition and a solo work, "To my creators…", later shown in Toronto. The residency's real product was the network: the artist-researcher relationships that continue through UKAI's board and the Creative AI Hub.

4. Contributions to Training

Master's supervision (Toronto Metropolitan University, Master of Digital Media — nine completed overall): supervisor for Emilie Trimbee, "AR-based Theatrical Design Pre-Visualization using Unreal" (2021); Lindsay Christopher, "Casting and Technology: Revamping the Audition Process" (2021); Shelby Bushell, "Collider: Using Virtual Reality for Immersive Theatre and the Performing Arts" (2021); Riley Erin Cooper (2020); and Yerachmiel Paquette (2020). Second reader for Aya Elmeligy, "Bridging Chasms" (2022); reader for Kenyth Thomason, MFA in Technical Direction and Production, Yale School of Drama (2020).

In November 2024, eight of my undergraduate students presented their own installation at AVARA in Oulu, Finland; their first international conference, built over a semester of research-creation. Toronto Metropolitan University offers no graduate degrees in my field, so this is what training looks like in my practice: undergraduates doing the real thing. My THT 582 class (2023) developed an off-site immersive installation with industry partners, integrating robotics, AI, and show systems. As coordinator of the Global Campus Studio course I connect TMU students with international collaborators.

5. Relevant Experience

In spring 2026, 33 submissions arrived for the 3rd Annual Creative AI Symposium; Dr. Afsoon Soudi and I reviewed all of them, built the program, and co-chaired the event at Toronto Metropolitan University on April 2. The symposium grew out of the Creative AI Hub at The Creative School, where I have served on the steering committee since its formation in 2025, and where I first appeared as a panelist at the inaugural 2024 symposium.

My experience organizing collaborative research events extends internationally. In 2024 I built a semester-long partnership between TMU and OAMK (Oulu, Finland), supported by Erasmus+ staff mobility funding, that culminated in a student installation and my closing keynote at AVARA 2024. As a board member of UKAI Projects I have participated in the Carnival of Shipwreck (2024) and the SÍM residency in Iceland, and as coordinator of the Global Campus Studio I maintain ongoing structures for international creative exchange. These partnerships — Finnish, Icelandic, and Canadian arts organizations, universities, and industry — are working relationships.

Before academia I spent two years at WorldStage's research and development lab in San Francisco, planning and executing technology-driven events across the USA and Macau for clients including Wynn, NBC Studios, Intel, and Nokia Bell Labs. At the School of Performance, I have overseen production seasons of twelve shows per year; budgets, timelines, venues, and partners are familiar terrain. Across these roles I have built the skills this kind of work asks for: project management to schedule and budget, interdisciplinary and academic-industry networking, knowledge mobilization through research-creation, and the habit of training students and emerging artists to move between academic and industry rooms.